

7.2 Copy Protection

Given the rampant piracy of movies and music today, these discs would be encrypted with copy protection technologies that will make it harder, if not impossible, for pirates to either duplicate or copy data from a copy-protected DVD. Some of the best-known companies in the business, such as Macrovision and Sony, are ready with commercial solutions which they remain tight-lipped about.

Sony, though, has gone ahead and released details about the copy protection scheme that is assumed to be on the Blu-ray DVDs once they become available in the market. Here are some of the details:

The Blu-ray content management system includes three primary components: Advanced Access Content System (AACS), "BD+", a Blu-ray-specific enhancement for content protection renewability, and 'ROM Mark', a measure unique to Blu-ray Disc to guard against mass production piracy or the mass duplication and sale of unauthorized copies of pre-recorded media.

In addition to AACS, there is another hitch called the ROM Mark. The ROM Mark technology embeds a unique and undetectable identifier in pre-recorded BD-ROM media such as movies, music and games. While invisible to consumers, this ROM Mark can only be mastered with equipment available to licensed BD-ROM manufacturers, essentially preventing unauthorised copies of a disc.

Finally there is BD+ which enables Blu-ray Disc specific programmable renewability enhancement that gives content providers an additional means to respond to organised attacks on the security system by allowing dynamic updates of compromised code. But there is a downside to these copy protections too.

For us inserting a disc in the player and then watching a movie, or listening to music for that matter or playing a game is